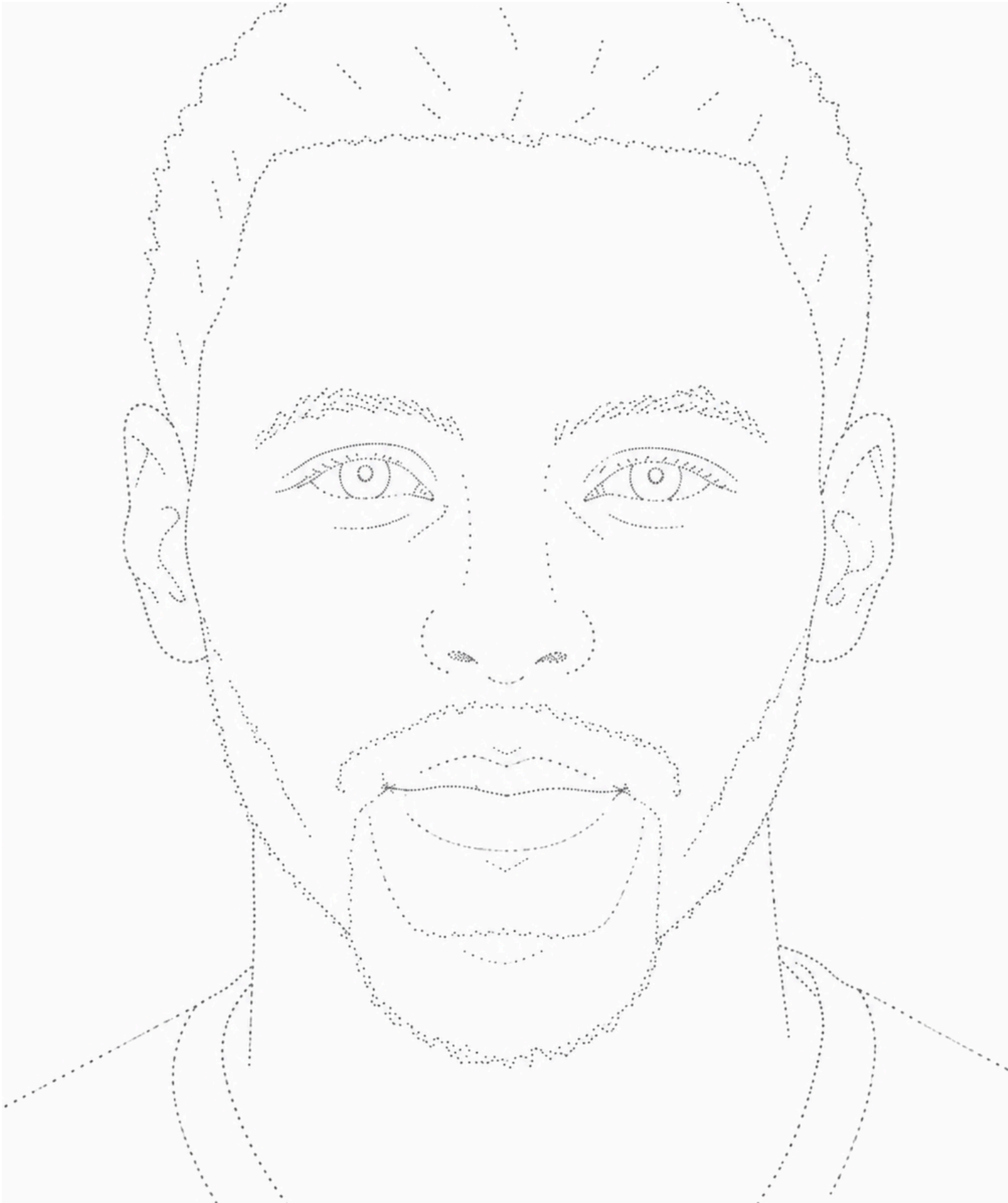


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



Portrait Guide #18

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–14 hours

Subject A young adult with medium-deep warm skin tone, curly short dark hair, a curly beard on the chin and jaw, wearing a grey top, photographed in three-quarter view with calm, neutral expression gazing slightly to the side.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



Cream

PC914

warm light base, lit plane foundation, burnishing key



Peach

PC939

warm mid-light for lit planes, subsurface luminosity glow



Ginger Root

PC1084

measured very-light warm orange, peak-lit local skin colour



Light Umber

PC941

measured mid-value warm orange, foundational skin depth



Rosy Beige

PC1019

warm rosy mid-tone, away-side plane unifier, neck form



Blush Pink

PC928

warm pink undertone, subsurface areas, away-side plane warmth



Terra Cotta

PC944

warm mid-dark for core shadow edge, cheekbone turn, nostril, beard warmth



Bronze

PC1028

warm shadow undertone, avoids grey ashy shadows, beard density, neck undershadow



Dioxazine Purple Hue

PC132

cool glaze inside core shadow for dimensional depth, never the plane itself



Indanthrone Blue

PC208

measured very-dark blue, cool iris radial strokes, deep shadow accent, beard cool layer



Chocolate

PC1082

warm dark for hair base, beard dense core, dimensional foundation



Chestnut

PC1081

warm mid-dark for hair richness, beard layer, curl texture depth



Black Cherry

PC1078

deep warm-cool dark for hair structure, beard cool layer, dimensional layering



Black

PC935

pupil core, upper lash line focal accent, deepest darks (punched back after burnish)



Crimson Red

PC924

lip undertone, warm red base for mouth colour, chromatic shadow



Pink Rose

PC1018

lip mid-tone, lower lip warmth and light, integrated with skin



Powder Blue

PC1087

sclera warm-cool balance, cool reflected light in eye shadow, never harsh white



70% French Grey

PC1074

measured mid-value garment grey, fabric texture, detail lines



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

warm grey for garment shadows, background variation, burnishing mid-tone



Grey Green Light

PC289

cool-warm background variation, spatial depth accent around figure

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

soft directional key light from upper-left, approximately 45–60° angle; warm-toned (possibly indoor tungsten or golden-hour direction); casts gentle shadows without harsh contrast

HIGHLIGHT

forehead apex, bridge and tip of nose, peak of cheekbone (lit side), lower-lip catch light, hair sheen bands where light crosses curl pattern

LIGHT AREA

full forehead, cheekbone, nose, upper-lit portion of upper lip, chin and beard if lit, front-facing temple area

MIDTONE

most of the face under even ambient fill; away-side plane (shadow-side of face) maintained as warm midtone, not dark; neck receives soft diffuse ambient light

SHADOW

core shadow along cheekbone ridge where plane turns away, under chin (soft self-shadow), eye socket, moustache shadow under nose, beard shadow on jaw underside, neck undershadow

CAST SHADOW

soft shadow cast by beard onto neck; shadow on garment where neck meets top, folds in grey top fabric, background variation

Edge quality notes

terminator between lit and shadow is soft and gradual on the rounded cheek (curving form in soft light), but sharpens at the cheekbone ridge (plane-edge definition); upper lash line is crisp focal accent; outer edges soft and lost (hair into background, jaw into neck, garment into ground)

• **STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS**

OI Value Map — Light Monochrome Foundation

entire face, neck, and visible garment

Monochrome light-to-dark value layering; circular strokes for form-following blends, directional strokes for planar separation. Light pressure throughout (2–3 on pencil pressure scale of 10), never dense.

Light pressure

- Colored pencil is non-liftable and transparent: value must be built light-to-dark through thin layering, and starting light preserves paper tooth for all layers to follow. A compressed value range reads flat; establish the full range now (highlight, lit plane, midtone, core shadow, reflected light, cast shadow) at light pressure in monochrome, never darkening beyond ~50% value — this preserves the luminous quality the reference soft light carries.
- Use PC914 Cream or PC1072 50% French Grey at very light pressure to block the peak highlights (forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peak) — these are the reference points for all value relationships.
- Lay light passes of PC1056 70% Warm Grey across the entire lit side (forehead, cheekbone, upper face) to establish the lit plane as a continuous warm-neutral form.
- Block the away-side plane (shadow-side of face) with the same PC1056 at light pressure, keeping it a TRUE MIDTONE — not dark, not soft blur. The core-shadow edge where the cheekbone ridge turns is crisp, not diffuse.
- Introduce PC1074 70% French Grey sparingly into the core shadows (under cheekbone, eye socket, under chin) to anchor the deepest value relationships without filling them yet.
- Indicate cast shadows (beard onto neck, garment folds) with even lighter touches of PC1074, preserving white paper for peak highlights.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC1072 50% French Grey



PC1056 70% Warm Grey



PC1074 70% French Grey

↔ PC914 Cream and PC1056 70% Warm Grey are warm-neutral value anchors; any light grey and mid-grey will work if unavailable, but avoid pure cool greys — the map must stay warm-neutral per maintain R10. PC1072 50% French Grey can be replaced by PC1070 30% French Grey (lighter) or PC1074 70% French Grey (darker) depending on value preference.

STOP WHEN

the full value range is visible and crisp (peak white to ~50% dark) · your hand is moving freely and the pencil is still sliding, not catching on paper texture

✦ *Do not be tempted to darken the shadows now. The reference is soft-lit and the away-side plane will stay a midtone throughout. If you darken here, you lose the ability*

to layer luminous colours on top — start light, darken gradually, and stop at the reference depth, never imagining a darker version.

O2 Skin Undertones — Lit Side Base & Midtone

forehead, cheekbone peak, nose, upper-lit lip area (lit planes only)

Optical mixing via thin, even layering in circular strokes; each pencil applied across the WHOLE zone before introducing the next, so the final colour is a fused blend visible on paper, not a gradient from pencil A to pencil B.

Light to Light-Medium (3–4 on scale of 10) pressure

- Subsurface scattering makes skin glow with prismatic undertones — yellow, peach, pink — that merge into one luminous local colour only when layered thin and even. A single 'skin-colour' pencil reads flat; building with distinct hues creates depth and aliveness. The measured skin tone is medium-deep and warm ($L^* \approx 49$), confirmed by the warm orange hues in the reference.
- First pass: layer PC914 Cream in very thin, even passes across the entire lit side (forehead, cheekbone, nose, bridge) using circular strokes. Do not blend yet; deposit colour evenly across the WHOLE zone per maintain R5.
- Second pass: layer PC939 Peach in the same zones, intensifying on the cheekbone peak and nose tip where subsurface light is warmest. Light pressure, circular strokes, preserving tooth.
- Third pass: layer PC1084 Ginger Root (the measured very-light orange) sparingly on the highest-lit points — nose bridge, forehead apex, cheekbone peak — to anchor the measured local colour without darkening the plane.
- Do not move to shadow colours yet; the lit side is a unified warm plane of Cream + Peach + Ginger Root, worked thin and even. This is the unifier layer and foundation for all depth to follow.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC939 Peach



PC1084 Ginger Root

↔ PC914 Cream, PC939 Peach, and PC1084 Ginger Root build the measured warm mid-light tone. If unavailable: Cream can substitute PC939 Peach (warmer), Peach by PC928 Blush Pink (warmer but works), Ginger Root by PC941 Light Umber (measured mid-value orange — darker, so use sparingly).

STOP WHEN

the lit plane glows with a uniform peachy-cream warmth and the paper texture is still faintly visible · the pencil is sliding smoothly and a finger rub does not redistribute the pigment significantly

✦ *Even coverage is non-negotiable here per maintain R5. Grain or streakiness in this layer will telegraph through every layer above. Work the whole zone in each pass, varying pressure only at the edge to soften the boundary with shadow areas. The lit plane is ONE surface, not separate highlights and mid-tones.*

03 Skin Planes — Away Side & Core Shadow

away-side plane (shadow-side of face from cheekbone through jaw), core-shadow edge (cheekbone ridge turn)

Directional layering following plane angle; the core-shadow edge is a crisp LINE created by directional short strokes, not a diffuse gradient. The glaze of cool purple is a thin transparent layer inside the shadow, visible up close but not dominating the plane's warmth.

Light-Medium (3–5 on scale of 10), heaviest at the core-shadow edge to crisp it pressure

- The away-side plane is a single warm midtone mass with ONE crisp core-shadow edge where structure turns inward — per maintain R4. Soft blur reads as no form; pushing it ashy or dark reads as no light. A warm midtone plane + one cool accent inside the core shadow = convincing turned form.
- First pass: layer PC1019 Rosy Beige across the entire away-side plane (shadow-side of face, from cheekbone down through jaw) in thin, even passes. Keep it a true midtone — not dark, not light. Use directional strokes following the plane's angle (down the cheek toward the jaw), not downward generic strokes.
- Second pass: layer PC928 Blush Pink into the same plane, intensifying in the cheek area where warm reflected light rises. This rosy undertone is what keeps the plane ALIVE and warm, never ashy.
- Third pass: identify the core-shadow edge (the crisp crease where the cheekbone ridge turns the plane away). Glaze PC944 Terra Cotta in SHORT passes along this edge only — this is a line, not a fill — to create the hard plane-separation the reference shows.
- Fourth pass: deepen INSIDE the core shadow (the shadow zone just behind the edge) with a glaze of PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue at very light pressure. This is a cool accent INSIDE the shadow, not the plane itself — the plane stays warm (Rosy Beige + Blush Pink), the shadow zone gets a cool glaze.
- Do not darken beyond a true midtone; the reference is soft-lit and this plane must remain convincing as a lit form that has turned away, not a dark mass.

COLORS  PC1019 Rosy Beige  PC928 Blush Pink  PC944 Terra Cotta

 PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue

↔ PC1019 Rosy Beige and PC928 Blush Pink are warm rosy undertones; either can replace the other if needed (adjust pressure to maintain midtone depth). PC944 Terra Cotta (warm mid-dark) can be replaced by PC1028 Bronze (slightly cooler, still warm). PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue is the cool glaze — any cool purple or blue-violet works, but avoid pure blue (it will read unnatural) per maintain R2.

STOP WHEN

the away-side plane reads as a unified warm midtone with one crisp structural edge ·
the purple glaze inside the shadow is barely visible (a colour shift, not a purple wash)
when you step back from the page

✦ *The away-side plane is the HARDEST step to get right because it is easy to over-darken or push it ashy — the commonest failure of maintain R4. Reference your value map: the away-side plane should be noticeably darker than the lit side, but still obviously LIT — a warm midtone, not a dark mass. The crisp core-shadow edge on the cheekbone ridge is what creates structure; the softness of the plane itself is what creates light. Do not conflate them.*

04 Eyes — Pupil, Iris Radial, Sclera & Lash Line

both eyes (pupils, iris, upper and lower lids, lash line, sclera)

Radial iris strokes (from pupil outward), sharp upper lash line (crisp linear edge), soft diffuse lower lid (blended). Specular highlight is lifted last, not rendered now.

Light-Medium (4–5 on scale of 10) for iris and sclera, Medium (5–6) for upper lash line (crisp, no smudge), Light (2–3) for lower lid pressure

- The eye is a sphere recessed in the socket; rendering it requires: (1) a dark pupil (deepest local value) to anchor form, (2) a dimensional iris built with radial strokes from center outward (not flat fill) in multiple hues, (3) a warm-toned sclera (never pure white), (4) a crisp upper lash line (the sharpest dark in the eye area, the focal accent) and (5) a softer lower lash line and lower-lid cast shadow. The upper and lower lids are asymmetrical in value and edge; mirroring them flattens the eye.
- Block PC935 Black for the pupil — a small circle, positioned slightly covered by the upper lid if the eyes are open. Do not outline; the pupil is a small filled circle.
- Layer PC208 Indanthrone Blue (the measured very-dark blue) in radial strokes from the pupil outward, like spokes on a wheel, radiating out to the iris edge. Ease pressure as you move outward to preserve luminosity at the iris edge; this is NOT filled flat.
- Weave PC1082 Chocolate or PC944 Terra Cotta into the warm-side iris (where light hits the sphere) — short radial strokes, not a full ring, so the iris reads as a 3D form lit from above.
- Surround the iris with PC1087 Powder Blue (sclera) — warm-toned, slightly grey-blue, never pure white. Keep the sclera warm by mixing in a glaze of PC914 Cream or PC1019 Rosy Beige at the corner nearest the nose and in the lower sclera, so the eye sits in the warm-lit face, not floating in white.
- Darken the upper lash line with PC935 Black, sharp and crisp — this is the only hard edge on the eye and the focal accent for the entire portrait. The upper-lid cast shadow (the shadow cast by the lid onto the upper sclera) is PC208 Indanthrone Blue or PC944 Terra Cotta at light pressure, soft edge.
- Lower lash line stays softer and more diffuse — PC208 or PC1087 blend, not a hard line. The lower lid is in the warm ambient light of the face, so blend it with the cheek colour below it.
- Reserve a single specular highlight (a small bright white dot) on the iris or upper sclera, placed to match the reference's light direction; do NOT paint this now — lift it in the final highlight step.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC208 Indanthrone Blue

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC944 Terra Cotta

● PC1087 Powder Blue

● PC914 Cream

● PC1019 Rosy Beige

↔ PC935 Black for pupil and upper lash line has no substitute; it is the focal accent. PC208 Indanthrone Blue for iris can be replaced by PC901 Indigo Blue (similar very-dark blue) or even PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue (if eyes are very dark-brown, a purple-leaning dark reads more natural than pure blue). PC1087 Powder Blue for sclera can be replaced by PC904 Light Cerulean Blue (if sclera reads cooler) or simple light grey (if the reference is more neutral).

STOP WHEN

the iris is three-dimensional (radial strokes still visible, not flat) and the upper lash line is crisp and dark · a finger rub on the iris does not obscure the spoke structure

✦ *The upper lash line is your SHARPEST edge on the entire portrait; reserve it as the focal accent. If every edge is equally sharp, the eye does not anchor the viewer's attention. Build the iris with visible radial structure — this is what makes an eye a sphere and not a flat disc. Do not obliterate the spoke pattern by over-blending.*

05 Lips — Undertone, Form & Edge Integration

upper and lower lips

Layered warm base (Crimson Red) + varied depth (Pink Rose brighter on lower lip, Terra Cotta/Bronze on upper-lip shadow) + integration via soft boundary (no outline). Horizontal creases deferred to the final detail step.

Light-Medium (3–4 on scale of 10) throughout, heaviest on upper-lip shadow to darken it, lightest at lip edges to integrate with skin pressure

- The lip is a form turned in light: upper lip is in its own shadow (darker, cooler), lower lip catches light (lighter, warmer, more saturated). If you render upper and lower with equal value and saturation, the form flattens. The lip line is soft and integrated with surrounding skin; hard outlining makes the lip look painted on rather than part of the face.
- Lay PC924 Crimson Red as the undertone across BOTH lips in very light, even passes — this is the red base colour that will vary in tone above it.
- Layer PC1018 Pink Rose over the lower lip, keeping it lighter and warmer than the upper lip. Use circular strokes blending into the surrounding cheek colour at the edge; the lip-skin boundary is a soft colour transition, not a line.
- Glaze PC944 Terra Cotta or PC1028 Bronze into the upper-lip shadow (the central or upper portion of the upper lip, depending on the reference's shadow pattern) to darken and cool it slightly. The upper lip is a shadow plane catching reflected warmth from the chin below, so keep it warm even as it darkens — per maintain R2.
- The lower lip's edge (especially the outer edge catching full light) stays softer and warmer. Blend PC914 Cream or PC1019 Rosy Beige at the lower lip's light edge to catch the subsurface glow.
- Do NOT outline the lip. If the lip line reads as a hard edge, it means the surrounding skin and lip colour are not integrated — the edge is the colour transition itself.

COLORS

 PC924 Crimson Red	 PC1018 Pink Rose	 PC944 Terra Cotta
 PC1028 Bronze	 PC914 Cream	 PC1019 Rosy Beige

↔ PC924 Crimson Red is the undertone base; PC926 Carmine Red or PC925 Crimson Lake can substitute (adjust pressure to reach the same depth). PC1018 Pink Rose for lower lip can be replaced by PC928 Blush Pink (warmer, more saturated, works well) or PC939 Peach (if lips are more peachy than pink). PC944 Terra Cotta for upper-lip shadow can be replaced by PC1028 Bronze or PC1082 Chocolate (darker, so use less pressure).

STOP WHEN

the lower lip reads lighter and warmer than the upper lip, and the lip-skin boundary is a soft colour transition · the lips sit convincingly in the warm-lit face, not floating above it

✦ *Lip shadows are WARM, never grey or ashy — per maintain R2. Even though the upper lip is in shadow, it glows with the warmth of the surrounding face and the reflected light from the chin. If your upper-lip shadow reads ashy or cool, you have lost the liveliness of the form.*

o6 Facial Hair / Beard — Curly Short Beard with Growth Direction

chin, jaw underside, area under nose (moustache zone), cheek boundary

Short directional strokes following growth (down chin, out-and-down jaw, out from philtrum). Warm dark + cool dark layered, never flattened. Sparse coverage at cheek boundary with skin colour between strokes. Sheen bands reserved for final step.

Light-Medium (3–5 on scale of 10) for growth strokes, heavier at the dense core (chin patch), lighter at the boundary to keep it sparse and open pressure

- Facial hair is a FORM with its own light and shadow, not a tint or wash over the skin. Built from the SKIN OUT: the light skin underneath the beard still glows warm (never disappears), and the dense core is built in SHORT STROKES following growth direction (down the chin, out-and-down the jaw, out from the philtrum under the nose). The boundary where beard thins into cheek skin is the ILLUSION — individual hairs separated by skin colour, never a hard painted edge. Per maintain R6: density gradient, warm+cool darks, sheen bands.
- Render the light skin layer underneath the beard first in the beard zone (chin, jaw underside) using PC914 Cream and PC1019 Rosy Beige in thin passes; the skin glows warm even under the beard.
- Build the dense core (chin patch, jaw underside, moustache mass) in SHORT strokes (~0.5 cm) following growth: down on the chin, out-and-down on the jaw, out from the philtrum. Layer PC1082 Chocolate as the warm dark base, short strokes, medium pressure.
- Introduce PC1078 Black Cherry or PC208 Indanthrone Blue for cool depth — layered OVER the warm dark, short strokes, intersecting the growth direction slightly so warmth and cool are both visible. Never one flat black; per maintain R6 (warm+cool layered).
- The cheek boundary is where beard thins to individual hairs with skin showing between: keep strokes SEPARATE and SPARSE in this zone, so the transition from dense beard to cheek skin is a gradual thinning of coverage, not a hard line. Overlap a few skin-tone strokes (PC1019 Rosy Beige) into the sparse boundary so skin reads between the hairs.
- Add 2–3 sheen bands (light crease or highlight curve) where light crosses the beard mass, using PC914 Cream at very light pressure; these are reserved for the final burnish step, so do NOT fill them now.
- The jaw edge IS the beard silhouette — the beard does not stop at the jaw; it IS the jaw edge in shadow. Do not outline the jaw separately.

COLORS  PC914 Cream  PC1019 Rosy Beige  PC1082 Chocolate

 PC1078 Black Cherry  PC208 Indanthrone Blue

↔ PC1082 Chocolate (warm dark base for beard) can be replaced by PC1081 Chestnut (slightly lighter, more warm) or PC1078 Black Cherry (slightly cooler, darker). PC1078 Black

Cherry or PC208 Indanthrone Blue (cool depth) can be substituted with any cool dark — PC901 Indigo Blue, PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue, or even PC904 Light Cerulean Blue used very sparingly. Never replace with pure grey or black without cool/warm layering.

STOP WHEN

individual short strokes are still visible (not blended into a uniform wash) and the cheek boundary shows skin colour between the beard hairs · the beard reads three-dimensional with depth (warm and cool visible) and a density gradient from dense core to sparse boundary

✦ *The beard is NOT stubble-shading — it is a three-dimensional form. The commonest error is to render it as a grey wash over the chin, flattening the face. Render the light skin underneath, then the dense core as SHORT strokes (not long downward slashes), then the sparse boundary. The jaw is now defined by hair silhouette, not a skin edge. If you see a hard painted border where beard meets cheek, soften it immediately by removing the hard line and replacing it with sparse, separate strokes showing skin between.*

07 Hair — Curly Short Hair with Density Gradient & Texture

entire head of curly short hair, including crown, temples, nape

Short curved strokes following curl contour (around the form, not downward). Density gradient (dense core, sparse boundary). Warm base + cool accent layering. Sheen bands reserved for burnish step. NO individual strands.

Light-Medium (3–5 on scale of 10) for base and mid-tone, Medium (4–6) for cool accent core, Light (2–3) for boundary thinning pressure

- Curly short hair is rendered as a light pattern across the whole mass, not individual strands. The density gradient is key: dense dark core between curl clumps, thinning at the boundary where individual curl separations and skin show through. Warm and cool layered (maintain R6) for depth; sheen bands where light crosses the curl pattern.
- First pass: establish the overall shape and value using PC1082 Chocolate in short curved strokes following the curl contour and mass direction (around the form, not down it). This is not full coverage; this maps the densest zones (typically the sides and back).
- Second pass: layer PC1081 Chestnut as a warm mid-dark to add richness and break up any uniform dark. Short curved strokes, following curl direction, with gaps between strokes so the base layer and paper texture show through.
- Third pass: introduce PC1078 Black Cherry or PC208 Indanthrone Blue sparingly (per maintain R6) in the densest zones (core of the mass, between clumps) for dimensional depth. These are cool accents, not a second base; use light pressure.
- Thin the boundary where hair meets background: allow individual curl separations and skin to show between strokes. This is where the hair thins visually; sparse, separate strokes create the illusion, not dense fill.
- Reserve sheen bands (1–2 light crease or highlight curves where light catches the curl pattern) using PC914 Cream at very light pressure; these are kept for the final burnish step so they glow when the surface is sealed.
- Do NOT render individual strands. Render the light playing across the textured mass — a density gradient, warm-and-cool layering, and sheen bands are what make hair read as hair, not a flat silhouette.

COLORS  PC1082 Chocolate  PC1081 Chestnut  PC1078 Black Cherry

 PC208 Indanthrone Blue  PC914 Cream

↔ PC1082 Chocolate (warm dark base) can be replaced by PC1081 Chestnut (lighter, more warm) or PC1078 Black Cherry (darker, more cool). PC1081 Chestnut can be replaced by PC1084 Ginger Root (lighter, more warm) or PC941 Light Umber (slightly cooler, more orange). PC1078 Black Cherry or PC208 Indanthrone Blue (cool accent) can be substituted with any cool dark — PC901 Indigo Blue, PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue, or even PC1087 Powder

Blue (much lighter, so use only at boundary). Sheen bands use PC914 Cream; if unavailable, any very light warm pencil works (PC1084 Ginger Root at ultra-light pressure).

STOP WHEN

short curved strokes are visible (not blended smooth) and the density gradient is evident (dark core, light boundary) · the boundary shows gaps between strokes (not solid fill) and the overall mass reads three-dimensional, not flat

✦ *Curly hair is built on contrast between dense core and sparse boundary, warm and cool layering, and a few sheen bands — not on individual-strand rendering. The commonest error is to paint hair in long downward strokes (as if it were long straight hair), which reads wrong for curls. Use short curved strokes, varying direction with the curl direction, and thin the boundary. Step back often: from a distance, hair reads as a textured mass; close up, you see the technical layers. Both must read correctly.*

08 Neck & Skin Refinement — Form, Soft Shadow & Garment Transition

neck (full visible length), undershadow of chin/jaw, skin-to-garment junction, lower jaw and cheek refinement

Thin even passes for refinement (per maintain R5). Undershadow built warm and soft. Garment bounce (if present) glazed subtly at very light pressure. Full-zone colour building for unity and luminosity.

Light (2–4 on scale of 10) for refinement passes, Light-Medium (3–4) for undershadow, very Light (1–2) for garment bounce glaze pressure

- The neck is a separate cylindrical form with its own value and temperature relationships: a soft self-shadow where the chin undercuts it, a warm-colour bounce from the garment when the garment is illuminated, and smooth transitions to the face above and garment below. Refine the entire face skin by evening out grain and building luminosity before moving to final details — per maintain R5.
- Layer the neck in PC1019 Rosy Beige and PC928 Blush Pink (same as face planes) to establish form and carry the face colour down. Keep the neck warm and mid-toned; it receives diffuse ambient light and glows warmly.
- Deepen the undershadow of the chin/jaw (the soft shadow where the chin projects over the neck) using PC944 Terra Cotta and PC1028 Bronze in light passes — kept WARM, not grey (per maintain R2). This shadow is what gives the neck its form separation from the chin above.
- Where the garment meets the neck, soften the edge in the shadow zone and keep it hard on lit edges. If the grey garment is catching light, a subtle violet-grey or warm-grey bounce may appear on the lower jaw and neck — glaze this sparingly (very light pressure) using PC1074 70% French Grey or PC1056 70% Warm Grey to unify the figure.
- Refine the entire face skin by ensuring no uneven grain or streaks remain (per maintain R5): lay thin passes of PC914 Cream and PC1019 Rosy Beige across the full face and neck to even out texture and build luminosity. Work across zones, not spot-treating, so the finish is unified.
- The face-to-neck transition is soft but present; do not blur away the lower jaw edge, but do integrate the colour so face and neck read as one continuous form in continuous light.

COLORS



PC1019 Rosy Beige



PC928 Blush Pink



PC944 Terra Cotta



PC1028 Bronze



PC1074 70% French Grey



PC1056 70% Warm Grey



PC914 Cream

↔ PC1019 Rosy Beige and PC928 Blush Pink are warm rosy undertones; either can replace the other. PC944 Terra Cotta and PC1028 Bronze are warm shadows; interchangeable (Bronze cooler, Terra Cotta warmer). PC1074 70% French Grey and PC1056 70% Warm Grey are garment-bounce glazes; either works depending on garment coolness. PC914 Cream is a

general warm light layer; if unavailable, PC939 Peach or PC1084 Ginger Root at light pressure works.

STOP WHEN

the neck reads as a unified cylindrical form with soft undershadow · the face and neck show no uneven grain, and the colour is even across the entire zone · the face-to-garment edge is soft where shadowed, crisp where lit

✦ *This step is your last chance to even out grain and build a unified skin surface before final details and burnish. Work the WHOLE zone in each pass, varying pressure only at boundaries. Uneven skin-colour application will telegraph through burnishing and look unfinished. Grain is a symptom of incomplete layering coverage — add thin passes across the whole zone until it vanishes per maintain R5.*

09 Garment & Background — Grey Top, Varied Ground & Edge Integration

visible grey top (shoulder, chest, and any visible sleeve), background (air/space around the figure), hard edges where figure meets background

Garment: directional creases following form contour (not wrinkles), fabric texture via subtle layering.
Background: varied hue and value (warm grey + cool-green grey), soft spatial recession away from figure. Deliberate edge-loss (hair into background) via softening and colour blending.

Light-Medium (3–5 on scale of 10) for garment planes, Light (2–3) for fabric creases, Light-Medium (3–4) for background, Light-Medium (4–5) for warm contact shadows to crisp them pressure

- The garment and ground are forms with their own light logic, never flat fill. A grey garment has fold shadows (warm, not grey), fabric texture (subtle directional creases), and a contact shadow where it meets the neck. The background is deliberately varied (not uniform) and at least one silhouette edge (usually hair) is deliberately LOST into it, creating spatial depth — the figure sits in space, not pasted on. Per active R11.
- Render the grey top using PC1074 70% French Grey for mid-lit planes and PC1056 70% Warm Grey for warmth and shadow variation. Vary pressure and direction to suggest fabric contour (shoulder slope, torso curve) without explicit wrinkles.
- Add fabric texture via subtle directional creases (short curved strokes following the shoulder and torso contour, like fabric folds follow form). These are shadow creases, not bright lines; darken the crease shadow with PC1028 Bronze or a light glaze of PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue (cool shadow — per maintain R2).
- Include contact shadows where the garment meets the neck or falls into a fold; keep these WARM using PC944 Terra Cotta or PC1028 Bronze, never grey (per maintain R2).
- For the background, use PC1056 70% Warm Grey on one side and PC289 Grey Green Light on the opposite side to create variety and prevent a flat, uniform field. Suggest soft form (a fold or shadow plane) in the ground so the space reads dimensional.
- DELIBERATELY LOSE the hair silhouette into the background on at least one side (usually the shadow side or outer edge) by softening the hair-background edge and allowing them to blend. Hard outline every edge and the figure reads pasted on; lose one edge and space opens up.
- Ensure the ground has its own light structure: a subtle highlight on one side of a fold, shadow in a dip, or directional variation in value so the figure clearly sits on or in the ground, not floating above it.

COLORS  PC1074 70% French Grey  PC1056 70% Warm Grey

 PC944 Terra Cotta  PC1028 Bronze  PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue

 PC289 Grey Green Light

↔ PC1074 70% French Grey and PC1056 70% Warm Grey are measured garment greys; any mid-light grey works if unavailable. PC289 Grey Green Light provides cool-green variation; if unavailable, any cool-neutral grey or very light cool green works. PC944 Terra Cotta and PC1028 Bronze are warm shadows; interchange per warmth preference.

STOP WHEN

the garment reads as a fabric form with texture and fold logic · the background varies in hue and value (not uniform grey) · the hair-background edge is soft and blended on at least one side (lost edge) · the ground suggests spatial form (fold, shadow, directional light) and the figure sits within it

✦ *A common error is to finish the face beautifully and leave the garment and ground flat and uniform. The subject is only as convincing as the space it sits in per active R11. Invest time in garment texture and background variation — they anchor the figure in space and prevent the 'floating head' read. The deliberately lost edge is your most powerful spatial tool: one soft, blended hair-into-background transition creates atmosphere and depth that hard edges everywhere cannot.*

IO Edge Hierarchy & Detail — Focal Accent Sharpness & Edge Integration

upper lash line (focal accent), outer face edges (hair, jaw, neck), garment silhouette, nostril and philtrum detail

Sharpening via adding dark to the upper lash line (hard edge). Softening via blending and diffusing outer edges (lost edges). Detail via light-pressure small accents (nostril shadow, philtrum crease, cheekbone accent).

Medium (5–6 on scale of 10) for upper lash line (crisp, no smudge), Light (2–3) for detail accents and edge softening, very Light (1–2) for philtrum crease pressure

- Hard edges advance and grab the eye; soft and lost edges recede. One focal accent (the upper lash line) is sharpest; all others are actively LOST moving outward (hair into background, jaw into neck, neck into garment). Edge hierarchy is focus control — it directs where the viewer looks and creates spatial coherence. Per maintain edge hierarchy.
- Reserve the sharpest, hardest edge for the upper lash line (where the eye focuses): darken and crisp this line with PC935 Black at medium pressure, a clean sharp edge, no softness. This is your ONLY hard edge in the entire portrait.
- Actively LOSE edges moving outward: soften the hair-background boundary (already partly done in garment step, now finish it), blend the jaw into neck shadow, integrate the neck into garment (no hard outline on the shoulder silhouette), allow the garment to fade into the ground at the outer edge.
- Refine the iris by sharpening any radial spoke that reads too soft (maintain clarity of the three-dimensional form), but keep the overall iris edge soft (only pupil and upper lash line are crisp).
- Add fine details at very light pressure: nostril shadow (a small dark accent inside the nostril, using PC944 Terra Cotta or PC1028 Bronze), philtrum crease (a thin light line down the center of the upper lip using PC1074 or a pencil-line pressure of any mid-grey), any visible cheekbone ridge accent (a light touch of PC914 Cream on the peak of the cheekbone to sharpen the highlight).
- Do NOT re-render surfaces in this step. Edge hierarchy is placement and softness, not colour application. Sharpen what is already there; do not add new colour.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC944 Terra Cotta

● PC1028 Bronze

● PC1074 70% French Grey

● PC914 Cream

↔ PC935 Black for upper lash line has no substitute. PC944 Terra Cotta and PC1028 Bronze for nostril shadow are warm darks; interchange. PC1074 70% French Grey for philtrum crease can be replaced by any light mid-grey or even a light cool pencil.

STOP WHEN

the upper lash line is visibly the sharpest, darkest edge on the entire face · outer edges (hair, jaw, neck, garment) are soft and integrated · fine details (nostril, philtrum, cheekbone) are subtle and do not overwhelm the face

✦ *Edge hierarchy is often overlooked but is critical to a believable portrait. A sharp edge everywhere reads flat and lifeless; one sharp focal accent (upper lash line) with lost edges everywhere else creates dimension and directs the viewer's attention. Soften by blending, diffusing, and integrating colour into surrounding areas — not by erasing or lightening, which creates gaps.*

II Final Highlights, Burnish & Wax Bloom Correction

entire face, neck, and garment (final seal and correction pass)

Peak highlights added with heavy pressure (hard value jump). Burnishing with light pencil (Cream or 50% French Grey) at heavy pressure until smooth. Wax bloom removed by gentle wipe or fixative. Deepest darks punched back with Black at medium pressure.

Heavy (7–8 on scale of 10) for peak highlights and burnishing, Medium (5–6) for punching darks back in, Varies (light for wipe, none for fixative) pressure

- Burnishing melts layers into a painted finish BUT wax blooms (lightens and hazes), and burnishing lifts values upward. The full protocol is: (1) burnish to seal surface, (2) punch deepest darks back in (REQUIRED, not optional), (3) wipe bloom gently or fixative. Peak highlights are added LAST with a hard value jump per maintain R3.
- Identify peak highlights from the reference: forehead apex, bridge and tip of nose, peak of cheekbone (lit side), lower-lip catch light, sheen bands in hair. These are TRUE peaks, not filled-in midtones.
- Add peak highlights with PC914 Cream or PC938 White at HEAVY pressure (7–8 on pencil pressure scale of 10) in small areas, using circular strokes. A hard value jump (white to midtone) is what reads as a peak; a soft gradient reads as filling.
- Burnish the lit planes (forehead, cheekbone, nose) using PC914 Cream at heavy pressure (7–8) in circular strokes until no paper texture or white flecks remain. The surface should feel smooth and the colours look merged and painted.
- Burnish the mid-tones (away-side plane, neck, garment) using PC1072 50% French Grey at medium-heavy pressure (6–7) in smooth circular strokes. This unifies the mid-range and closes the paper tooth.
- Expect wax bloom to rise during burnishing — the surface may read lighter and softer than desired. This is normal and will be corrected.
- Punch the deepest darks back in: using PC935 Black at medium pressure (5–6), re-darken the core shadows (cheekbone ridge shadow, eye socket, beard core, hair core), upper lash line, and any cast shadows. This RESTORES the value range that bloom lightened.
- Wipe the wax bloom gently with a soft cloth (microfiber or cotton), wiping lightly in the direction of hair or downward (not scrubbing, which lifts pigment). Alternatively, apply light workable fixative per brand instructions.
- The finished portrait should span from near-white (peak highlights) to near-black (deepest shadows), with no crushed midtones and visible colour throughout.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC938 White



PC1072 50% French Grey



PC935 Black

↔ PC914 Cream and PC938 White for peak highlights both work; Cream is warmer and works well for warm-lit faces. PC1072 50% French Grey for burnishing mid-tones can be replaced by

any light-to-mid grey (PC1068 10% French Grey, PC1060 20% Cool Grey, etc.) — adjust pressure to reach smoothness without lifting colour. PC935 Black for punch-back has no substitute.

STOP WHEN

peak highlights are bright and crisp (hard value jump, not gradient) · the burnished surface is smooth and glossy (no paper texture visible) · after bloom removal and dark punch-back, the portrait spans full value range (light to dark) with no washed-out midtones

✦ *Wax bloom is your signal that burnishing worked; expect it. Panicking and over-wiping is a common error — a single gentle wipe or one light fixative pass is enough. Punching the darks back is MANDATORY and is often skipped; this step turns a hazy washed-out finish into a living portrait. The value range (light to dark) is what makes the portrait convincing; do not sacrifice it in the name of smoothness.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.